

Bobapedia: A Workshop on Archiving Living Flavor Experiences

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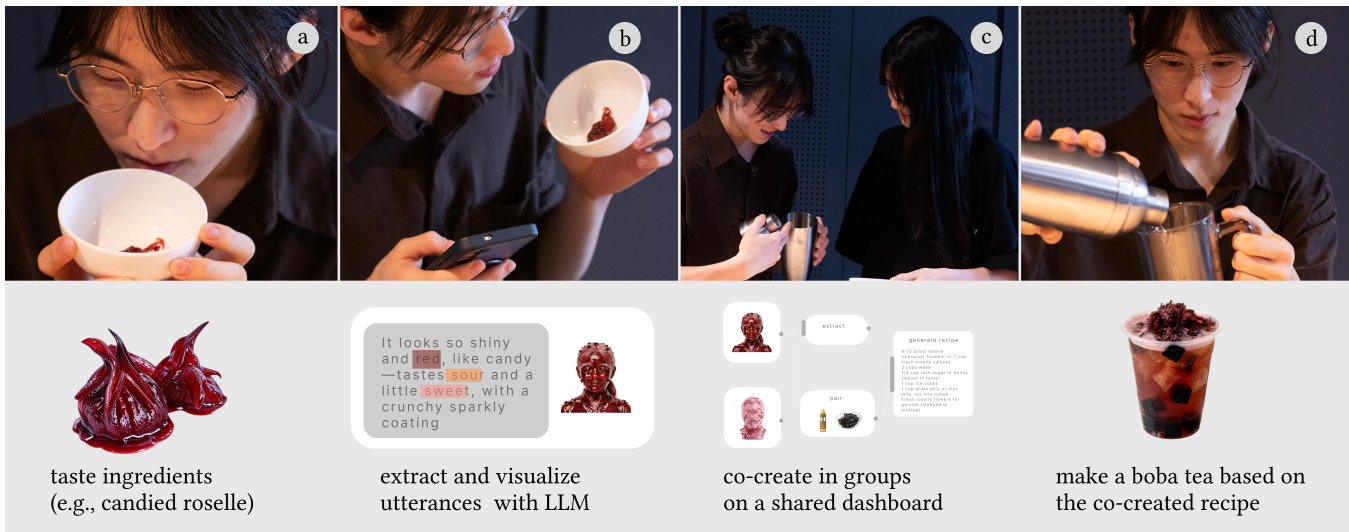


Figure 1: An example workflow in this workshop, illustrating how subjective flavor experiences are externalized, structured, and recomposed into a shared recipe. (a) Participants taste and smell the ingredients (e.g., candied roselle as an example). (b) Participants describe their flavor experience, which is recorded and visualized by an agentic system as an automatically generated knowledge graph. (c) Participants form groups to discuss and co-edit their flavor concepts on a shared dashboard. (d) Participants prepare a boba tea based on the group discussion and the resulting generated recipe.

Abstract

Flavor is an embodied, multimodal, and culturally situated design material. However, computational flavor systems often represent food through ingredients, chemical compounds, recipe corpora, or machine-generated recommendations, leaving limited space for people to document and iterate their subjective experiences. We propose *Bobapedia*, a full-day participatory workshop exploring how computational interfaces scaffold collaborative flavor creation of a popular drink—boba tea. We will use an LLM-supported *Flavor Wiki* system to record participants’ sensory impressions, personal

and cultural associations, flavor interpretations, and finally guide them to iteratively create customized drinks.

Keywords

Human-food interaction, computational flavor creation, human-AI co-creation, participatory workshop

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1 Introduction

Flavor is a multisensory construct that is an integration of multiple senses and sociocultural, mnemonic dimensions [3, 22]. Human-Food Interaction (HFI) explores this field as a broad design space



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for computational approaches [12]. Previous works have modeled flavor data using recipes and chemical compounds, such as [1], FlavorGraph [21], FlavorDB [8], and, more recently, LLM agents for flavor hypotheses [10]. Researchers also have explored multimodal flavor presentation, which highlights the potential to computationally create new experiences. For example, AR pseudo-gustatory displays [18, 19] and chemical taste and smell interfaces [4, 6, 13].

However, current technology for reconstructing flavor experience still has clear limits. For example, some details, such as smell and flavor, are hard to verbalize because of limited olfactory vocabulary and cross-linguistic variation [14] to evolve from the existing flavor profile taxonomy [7, 15]. This leaves a room for data-driven systems to understand how flavor is interpreted subjectively, especially situated accounts shaped by life experiences and cultural contexts posing technical problems for HFI research [16]. There are prior tools helping individuals externalize ephemeral taste, such as the FlavourFrame using layered visual–textual canvases for mindful tasting [2], and FlavorDesigner supporting structured capture of multisensory experiences and personalized flavor-memory cues [9].

In this workshop, we extend from individual to collaborative, co-editing accounts for better capturing social effects. In brief, we focus on a key question: *how might computational interfaces help communities articulate, share, and iteratively refine their personal interpretations of taste?*

We choose boba tea as our medium to explore the question for both its cultural content and functional features. Boba tea carries a long history of cultural adaptation from the movement of tea and sugar through colonial trade across continents to thriving industry adapting into different culture zone [11, 20]. Beyond this historical context, much of this popularity also stems from standardized menus paired with extensive freedom to customize—sweetness, ice level, milk type, tea base, and toppings—positioning boba tea as a lightweight form of participatory food design.

2 Participants and Recruitment

The workshop aims to attract 30 participants from HFI, multisensory human-computer interactions, human-AI co-creation, and culinary practice; no culinary skills are required. We recruit participants with diversity of background using short open-ended questions: (1) language, (2) cultural region, and (3) professional backgrounds, and select by balancing groups with these aspects.

3 Workshop Activities

Bobapedia is a full-day workshop, moving from individual sensory documentation to group comparison, concept design, and iteration.

Task 1 — Flavor Entity Creation

Participants taste and smell assigned ingredients; the system assists them in describing sensory attributes. Participants experience how utterances collapse to generic terms and custom visualization (Figure 1b). This session also breaks the ice while participants practice articulating flavor.

Time	Block	Activity
09:00–10:20	Opening & Talks	Welcome and invited talks
10:20–10:30	Technique	Boba-making demo
10:30–12:15	Task 1	Flavor entity creation + system intro
12:15–13:45	Lunch	Conference lunch break
13:45–14:50	Task 2	Ingredient-led boba design; document in wiki
14:50–15:50	Task 3	Memory- or theme-driven boba; document in wiki
15:50–16:20	Share	Present drinks, open tasting & wiki annotation
16:20–17:00	Discussion & Close	Group reflection, research directions, closing

Table 1: The workshop schedule. Tasks follow an iterative cycle; regroup after each round.

Task 2 — Ingredient-Led Design

Groups select an anchor ingredient from the shared pool, design a boba tea around it, and record rationale and expected sensory profile in the wiki before preparing and tasting.

Task 3 — Memory- and Theme-Driven Design

Groups reshuffle, identify a shared memory or theme, and translate it into a boba concept using earlier flavor entries as building blocks, tracing ingredients back to that theme in the wiki.

Sharing, Discussion, and Close

Groups present their drinks alongside Flavor Wiki entries. Participants then circulate to taste one another’s creations and add annotations to shared wiki entries beyond their own group’s contributions.

An extended discussion addresses tensions between participants, LLM normalization and idiosyncratic expressions. Throughout this phase, a shared dashboard displays aggregated flavor visualizations and co-created archives so participants can compare ideas and design decisions across teams (Figure 1c).

4 Health and Dietary

We will ensure ingredients fit common allergen, religious (e.g., halal), vegan, and low-sugar requirements, or provide alternatives when needed.

5 Organizers

The organizing team brings together expertise in flavor and chemical interfaces, multisensory, multimodal AI, and participatory food design. Brooks and Narumi have previously hosted workshops on smell, taste, and human–food interaction [5, 17].

6 Expected Outcomes and Future Work

The workshop will produce a collaboratively edited Flavor Wiki—annotated ingredient entries and boba tea concepts capturing not only recipes, but the sensory, cultural, and narrative reasoning from individuals.

We will publish these materials on the workshop website. More broadly, the workshop aims to build a research agenda that connects

data-driven flavor models with embodied experience and supports interpretive diversity. We also explore how computational systems can help communities co-edit and extend everyday food knowledge. This agenda can inform future work across HFL, gastronomy, multisensory interaction, and human–AI creativity support.

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